



enriching. He said, “The environment was quite chill and light-hearted. I found it fascinating to learn about their lives and daily routines as chess players. It also made me realise the importance of fitness in the sport and that I’d be better off focusing more on it.”

This title may be MGD1’s biggest moment yet, but for Indian players,

flourishing in such events is standard practice. In recent years, they’ve repeatedly shown that they can thrive just as successfully in team formats as they do in individual ones.

“Indian chess players are usually very motivated and work well together in team events,” said Srinath. “Maybe the identity of being Indians gives them a strong sense of

Bonding: MGD1’s players built strong chemistry in no time. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

unity.” This was evident in 2024, when the national team clinched historic gold medals in both the Open and Women’s events at the Chess Olympiad — building on a strong showing the previous year, when both squads had secured silver at the Asian Games in Hangzhou.

Meanwhile, on the individual front, besides Divya Deshmukh’s World Cup win, Gukesh’s World Championship triumph over Ding Liren last year stands out as an epochal moment. Praggnanandhaa, too, recently won titles at the Grand Chess Tour Superbet Classic in Romania and the UzChess Cup in Tashkent.

While these achievements bode well for Indian chess, Sreekar points out that the sport still appeals to a niche audience. **This is where, according to him, the Team Championships can make a difference.**

“There’s greater interdependence, which makes the game more human. That, in turn, makes it more exciting and accessible to a wider audience,” he said.



Off the board: Divya Deshmukh of the Hexamind team shares a light moment with MGD1’s Stavroula Tsolakidou during the tournament. RAFAL OLEKSIWICZ/FIDE